

Can you hear the beat?

The beat is not always audible, through long notes for instance, but it continues as a regular measure of time. Performers nearly always keep counting, or feeling, the beat in their head, even through slow music, or long notes, or when they aren't playing.



1 2 1 2

△ Counting beats

Musicians feel the pulse, the steady flow of beats. Most of the time they count beats without thinking about it.

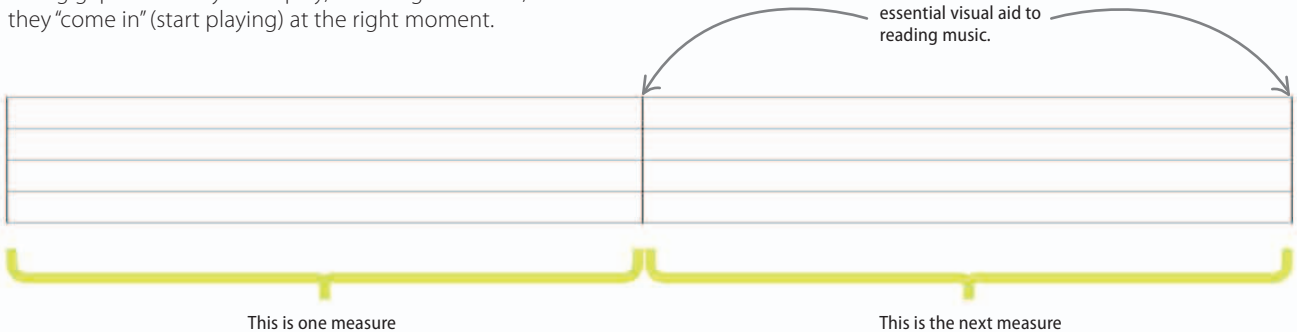
Measures and bar lines

The meter—the grouping of beats into a regular pattern of strong and weak beats—is marked off in measures. Measures and bar lines help performers keep track of where they are, and ensure that they keep playing together. The first beat in each measure is a strong beat. Musicians, particularly in orchestras, spend a lot of time counting beats and, if there's a long gap when they don't play, counting measures, so that they "come in" (start playing) at the right moment.

▽ Bar lines

Bar lines are drawn through the staff so that music can be read one measure at a time.

Bar lines separate one measure from another, and are an essential visual aid to reading music.



REAL WORLD

The conductor shows the beat



The most important role of a conductor is to set the beat and tempo of the composition. Conductors use patterns associated with the different meters, which are widely understood by singers and instrumentalists. The first beat of each measure is normally indicated by a downbeat. In slow-moving music, the conductor may show the beat although no new notes are being played.

Differences in musical terminology between the US and Britain: Americans use **"measure"** for **"bar"** and **"measure number"** for **"bar number."** **"Bar line,"** however, means the same in both countries.